DRAFT

Shelter-in-Place Basics

Sheltering in place means staying inside, or moving into a nearby building, to reduce exposure to a danger outside.

EVS-007

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

The right action depends on the hazard. A safe location for severe wind may be unsafe during a flood, fire, or chemical release. Follow current instructions from the responsible public agency. If officials order evacuation, do not remain simply because this plan says “shelter.”

ACT QUICKLY

1. **Go indoors.** Enter the nearest suitable building. Do not travel across a hazard to reach a preferred location.
2. **Bring people and animals in when safe.** Do not delay or go back into danger. Use leashes, carriers, or other restraints if they are within reach.
3. **Close openings.** Close and lock exterior doors and windows. Follow officials' instructions about ventilation, fans, fireplaces, dampers, or sealing a room; those actions vary by hazard.
4. **Move to the hazard-appropriate location.** Take essential supplies and help anyone who needs mobility, communication, medical, or other support.
5. **Monitor official information.** Use the alert source below and keep checking for changes, evacuation orders, or an all-clear.
6. **Preserve communication.** Keep a phone or radio with you, use low-power mode, dim screens, text instead of calling when practical, and reserve emergency calls for emergencies.

CHOOSE FOR THE HAZARD—NOT BY HABIT

Severe wind or tornado

Use a basement or a small interior room on the lowest level of a sturdy building, away from windows. Protect your head and neck. A vehicle or mobile/manufactured home is not a safe tornado shelter; use the sturdy shelter identified in your plan when you can reach it safely.

Chemical release

Follow the issuing agency's exact location and ventilation instructions. Officials may direct you to an interior room with few windows or exterior doors and tell you whether to shut down air-handling equipment and seal openings. Do not assume wind-storm or smoke actions apply.

Smoke or poor outdoor air

Follow official air-quality and public-health instructions. For choosing and setting up a cleaner-air room, use **EVS-008**; this handout does not replace its smoke-specific guidance.

Fire, flood, or other threat

An interior room is not a universal refuge. Rising water may require movement to higher ground, and fire or structural damage may require immediate escape. Use the protective action and destination named by officials.

Shelter-in-Place Basics — continued

⌖ LOCAL INFORMATION — VERIFY BEFORE APPROVAL

LOCAL SHELTER INSTRUCTIONS / ALERT CHANNELS — VERIFY BEFORE USE

Responsible agency: _____
Official shelter instructions: _____
Official alert channel or enrollment page: _____
Verified directly with agency by: _____ **Date:** _____

Leave entries blank until checked against a current, agency-controlled source. Incident instructions override this planning handout.

KEEP THESE SUPPLIES WITHIN REACH

- ☐ **Communication:** charged phone, power bank and cables; battery or hand-crank radio; written contacts
- ☐ **Light:** flashlights or headlamps and spare batteries—use these instead of candles
- ☐ **Water:** stored drinking water for people and animals
- ☐ **Necessary medicines:** labeled medicines, dosing information, and temperature control as required
- ☐ **Sanitation:** hygiene items, toilet supplies, waste bags, hand-cleaning supplies, and animal cleanup items
- ☐ **Individual support equipment:** mobility and communication aids, glasses, hearing-device supplies, backup power, service-animal supplies, and other daily essentials

PREVENT CARBON MONOXIDE POISONING AND FIRE

! WARNING — URGENT ACTION

Never use fuel-burning equipment indoors. A generator, charcoal grill, camp stove, gasoline engine, or other combustion device can produce deadly carbon monoxide (CO), an odorless, colorless gas.

- Operate a portable generator outdoors, at least 20 feet from the home, with exhaust pointed away from doors, windows, and vents. Never use it in a home, basement, garage, shed, carport, or other enclosed or partly enclosed space.
- Keep working battery-powered or battery-backup CO alarms near sleeping areas, and follow the manufacturer's placement and maintenance instructions.
- Never heat a home with a gas oven or range. Never burn charcoal indoors. Keep combustion devices away from dry materials and never refuel a hot generator.
- If a CO alarm sounds, or anyone develops headache, dizziness, weakness, nausea, vomiting, chest pain, or confusion, get everyone—including animals—to fresh air away from the suspected source and call emergency services. Do not re-enter until responders say it is safe.

Shelter-in-Place Basics — continued

LEAVE THE SHELTER ONLY WHEN

- **Officials direct a move:** follow an evacuation order, relocation instruction, or all-clear and use the route or precautions they give.
- **The location becomes immediately unsafe:** fire, rising water, structural failure, a gas odor, a CO alarm, or dangerous symptoms may require immediate movement away from the danger and a call to emergency services.

Before opening doors or moving outside, check the latest official message when possible. During a chemical or airborne hazard, leaving may increase exposure; move only under official direction unless remaining presents an immediate danger.

WRITE THE HOUSEHOLD PLAN

Primary shelter location: _____

Alternate location: _____

Official alert source: _____

Support contact (name and method): _____

SOURCES

Sources: Ready.gov, “Shelter” and “Chemical Emergencies”; National Weather Service, “During a Tornado”; Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, “Carbon Monoxide Poisoning Basics.” Accessed 2026-09-25.